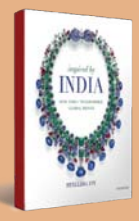
INSPIRED BY INDIA: HOW INDIA TRANSFORMED GLOBAL DESIGN
By Phyllida Jay
ROLI BOOKS
₹4045; 256 pages





STYLE OF INDIA
by Geeta Khanna
HACHETTE
₹2500; 309 pages

'India' and 'Global Design' being vast expressions, Jay focuses on a few chapters that cover 300 years of cross-cultural exchange

'Leisure, Pleasure and Masquerade' describes Indian textiles as accoutrements of 18th century nouveau riche taste and sensual pleasure (a version of "cross-cultural dressing" in our Instagram age). At a 1768 London masquerade, the rapacious Clive of India came "dressed up like an Indian nabob... very richly ornamented with diamonds to an immense value". Some years later, Marie Antoinette's portrait in diaphanous Indian muslin caused a scandal and had to be withdrawn.

An insightful if cautionary account, 'From Kashmir to Paisley' relates the death of high value textiles of superlative handwoven skill developed in Mughal times. Once coveted by the European elite, Kashmir shawls, later coarsely mass produced on looms in Scottish towns such as Paisley, ruined Indian weavers and destroyed the shawl industry. Looping back, however, the motif thrived as pop psychedelia of the Swinging Sixties and beyond—the musician Prince's song 'Paisley Park' was his record and studio label.

Reinterpreting—some would say transmogrifying—the sari at the hands of such hallowed names of western fashion such as Schiaparelli, Balenciaga, Chanel, Dior, Versace and Galliano yielded a number of quixotic visuals and stories. A striking poster of Audrey Hepburn in a sari-inspired dress by Givenchy for the 1961 film *Breakfast at Tiffany's* had Jackie Kennedy speedily copy it for a White House dinner for the Indian president.

As plundered loot or as specimens of virtuoso skill, any account of Indian gemstones promises readers full bling for their buck. There is a cartoon showing Warren Hastings excreting diamonds during his corruption trial; rare early 20th century photographs of French jewellers Cartier and Boucheron dealing with Indian diamond merchants; and the rise of Goa-born Ambaji Shinde who ended up as chief designer to Harry Winston for 40 years.

Comparisons are odious but in contrast to Phyllida Jay's original, precise, visually rich exhuming of archives, Geeta Khanna's *Style of India* starts with the Paleolithic Age and the Indus Valley and ends with contemporary fashion design. Like a large cupboard crammed with things of greater and lesser value, it takes in everything betwixt and between. If the idea was to produce an illustrated style handbook, it ends up as an all-purpose scrapbook.

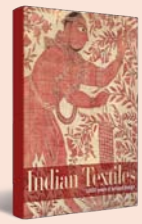
Fashions change, and a recent shift in the burgeoning domestic market is the flurry of investments by retail arms of the Reliance and Aditya Birla groups in a dozen designers, including Tarun Tahiliani, Manish Malhotra, Ritu Kumar, Abu Jani and Sandeep Khosla et al even as Sabyasachi prepares to launch his New York store. Brand India is set to scale new heights. ■

-Sunil Sethi

For the Big Picture

Recently released books to flaunt on your coffee tables

INDIAN TEXTILES: 1,000 YEARS OF ART AND DESIGN
by Karun Thakar, Rosemary Crill, Avalon Fotheringham, Sylvia Houghteling and Steven Cohen
HALI BOOKS
₹8,625; 391 pages



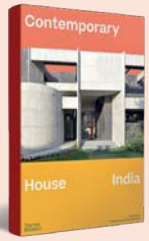
Held at the George Washington University Museum earlier this year, the exhibition *Indian Textiles* showcased court weavings, folk embroideries and other fabrics that spanned over 1,000 years (from the eighth to the 20th century). Both visuals and essays in this accompanying catalogue are revelations.



JAIPUR SPLENDOR
by Mozez Singh
ASSOULINE
₹9,766; 312 pages

Jaipur affords its visitors so many delights that each leaves the city with impressions that are often varied and unique. If the stunning pictures in *Jaipur Splendor* are anything to go by, Mozez Singh seems to know only too well how the Pink City experience is innately kaleidoscopic.

CONTEMPORARY HOUSE INDIA
by Robert Gregory (Author), Edmund Sumner (Photographer)
THAMES & HUDSON
₹3,995; 272 pages



Besides showing how the Indian architecture scene is thriving, this book situates the work of leading architects—Samira Rathod Design Associates, Martand Khosla, et al—in a global context. Featuring nearly 20 homes from across the country, the remarkable overview shows the world how we now live.